

The Purple Card Goes North

Nubank and the Decision to Take Digital Banking from Brazil to Mexico

Case analyzed: Chu, M., Larangeira, C., & Levindo, P. (2020). *Nubank: Democratizing Financial Services* (HBS Case No. 321-068). Harvard Business School – Latin America Research Center.

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1. The case I chose and where the story takes place

From the Harvard Business School *Latin America* page I selected **Nubank: Democratizing Financial Services**, a 33-page case by Michael Chu, Carla Larangeira and Pedro Levindo of HBS's Latin America Research Center (Chu et al., 2020; Harvard Business School, n.d.). It follows David Vélez, the Colombian founder and CEO of Nubank, when his company—"a wholly-digital solution created to disrupt Brazilian banking, with 6 million clients and a \$4 billion valuation after five years"—must decide whether to expand to Mexico, which Vélez saw as "the gateway" to a Latin America that shared "the same banking pain points as Brazil" (Chu et al., 2020). I chose it because it links the two largest economies of Latin America, because its outcome is unfolding in my own country today (Nu México became a licensed bank in July 2026 with 16 million customers), and because it illustrates the central lesson of this course: the Americas share many pain points, but country differences still decide which strategies work.

Geographical location. Nubank was born on May 6, 2013, in a small rented house in Brooklin, a neighborhood in the south of São Paulo—the largest city of South America and Brazil's financial capital, home to the B3 stock exchange and the headquarters of the largest private banks (Financial Times, 2025; Sequoia Capital, 2021). Brazil is a Portuguese-speaking federal republic of about 212 million people and the largest economy in Latin America. The decision in the case points north, toward Mexico (North America, about 126 million people at the time), where Nubank opened an office in Mexico City in April–May 2019 under general manager Emilio González (Mexico News Daily, 2022). The story thus stretches across the two poles of Latin America—the South Atlantic giant and the Spanish-speaking neighbor of the United States—with Colombia, Vélez's homeland and Nubank's third market in 2020, in between.

2. The business environment: economic, political, regulatory and cultural context

2.1 Brazil's economy in the 2010s: a rich banking oligopoly in a poor decade

The Brazil in which Nubank grew up was living its worst recession in modern history. Real GDP fell 3.5% in 2015 and 3.3% in 2016, inflation passed 10%, the central bank raised the Selic policy rate from 11% in mid-2014 to 14.25% by July 2015, and unemployment climbed to around 13% in 2017 (IMF, 2019). Paradoxically, the banking system remained extremely profitable. Five institutions—Itaú Unibanco, Bradesco, Banco do Brasil, Caixa Econômica Federal and Santander Brasil—controlled roughly 80% of assets and more than 80% of credit, far above the ~50% concentration of the United States, and private banks earned returns on equity in the mid-to-

high teens thanks to wide spreads and heavy fees (Seafarer Funds, 2022; U.S. Department of State, 2025). Credit cards were the most visible symptom: Brazilians paid annual fees on cards whose revolving interest rate was the most expensive credit in the country—still 431.6% per year in 2023, even after the central bank limited revolving balances to 30 days in 2017 (Reuters, 2023). Meanwhile, 45 million adults had no bank account—86% of them from the C, D and E income classes and 39% in the poorer Northeast—yet moved an estimated R\$817 billion a year in cash (G1, 2019), and only about 60% of Brazil's 5,570 municipalities had a bank branch (Nubank, 2019). Two technological shifts turned this frustration into an opportunity: smartphones spread across all income classes, and cloud computing (Nubank ran on Amazon Web Services from day one) made it possible to run a bank without branches or mainframes. The macro cycle helped too: as the Selic fell to 6.5% in 2018 and 4.5% by the end of 2019, incumbents' interest income came under pressure while cheap global capital was hunting for growth in emerging markets.

2.2 Politics and regulation: from Lava Jato to a pro-competition central bank

Politically, the decade was turbulent: mass protests in June 2013 (one month after Nubank was founded), the *Lava Jato* corruption investigation from 2014, the impeachment of President Dilma Rousseff in 2016, the unpopular Temer interlude and, in October 2018, the election of Jair Bolsonaro on a liberal economic agenda led by minister Paulo Guedes (IMF, 2019). For a start-up this meant currency volatility, a deep consumer-credit downturn and uncertainty about the rules of the game. The regulatory story, however, moved in Nubank's favor. Law 12,865 of 2013 created the *payment institution*, which let a non-bank issue a credit card under central bank supervision—the framework under which the purple card was launched in 2014. Because Nubank was foreign-controlled, it needed a presidential decree, signed by Temer in January 2018, before the Banco Central do Brasil (BCB) authorized Nu Financeira as a financial institution on November 23, 2018, ending its dependence on partner banks to fund credit and opening the door to personal loans and a debit card (Seu Dinheiro, 2018). In April 2018 the National Monetary Council created licenses for lending fintechs (Resolution 4,656), and the BCB's *Agenda BC+/BC#* explicitly promoted competition and inclusion, later delivering the instant-payment system Pix (November 2020) and Open Finance (2021), one of the fastest and most comprehensive implementations in the world (U.S. Department of State, 2025). The regulator, in short, was not an obstacle but an ally trying to break the oligopoly—a crucial difference when comparing Brazil with Mexico.

2.3 Culture: distrust of banks, love of credit and the power of word of mouth

Brazilians had a deeply ambivalent relationship with banks. Vélez himself needed five months, security doors, a guard and stacks of documents to open an account when he moved to São Paulo in 2008 (Stanford Graduate School of Business, 2022). Banking meant queues, hidden tariffs and condescending service, yet the credit card was a symbol of belonging: purchases are habitually split into interest-free installments, and 51% of the unbanked borrowed a friend's or relative's card to shop (G1, 2019). Brazil is also one of the most intensive users of social media in the world, so a transparent, fee-free purple card managed from an app spread almost entirely by referral, earned the nickname *roxinho* and generated a waiting list of millions; the brand name—*nu*, “naked”—promised transparency in a market that had none. Finally, Brazil's size and regional inequality mattered: a digital bank could reach the Northeast and the interior where branches did not exist, which is why Nubank was present in 100% of Brazilian municipalities within five years (Nubank, 2019).

2.4 The target market: Mexico in 2019

Mexico looked like Brazil's pain points multiplied. Only 47% of Mexicans aged 18–70 had an

account with a bank or financial institution in 2018, 68% had at least one formal financial product and just 31% had formal credit (INEGI, 2018; CONDUSEF, 2019). Cash dominated everyday life—even in 2024, 85% of adults still used cash as their main payment method for purchases under 500 pesos (INEGI, 2025)—and more than half of the workforce was informal (54.6% in December 2025 according to INEGI's ENOE), which makes traditional credit scoring difficult. The banking system was, like Brazil's, an oligopoly, but a mostly foreign-owned one—BBVA, Citibanamex, Santander, Banorte, HSBC and Scotiabank—with high annual fees. Politically, Andrés Manuel López Obrador had just taken office (December 2018) with a discourse critical of bank commissions, and Banco de México was preparing its own QR-payment system, CoDi (September 2019). Mexico had passed Latin America's first comprehensive Fintech Law in March 2018, but the ladder to becoming a bank was long: Nubank would have to start as a non-bank lender (SOFOM), buy a *Sociedad Financiera Popular* (Akala, September 2021) to take deposits, and only in April 2025 obtain CNBV approval to become a bank—the first SOFIPO ever allowed to do so (Fintech Futures, 2025; Mexico News Daily, 2022). Culturally, Mexico shares Latin America's distrust of banks, but with a stronger cash habit, a different credit-bureau infrastructure, remittance-dependent households and a consumer who had never seen a large digital bank succeed.

3. Historical context: global events that shaped the story

Nubank is a child of the 2008 global financial crisis, which destroyed trust in incumbent banks, pushed interest rates in rich countries to zero and sent venture capital looking for growth in emerging markets—and which brought Vêlez to Brazil in 2008 to open a private-equity office. The smartphone revolution and cloud computing made branchless banking possible, and Chinese platforms such as Tencent's WeChat Pay provided both a model and, in 2018, an investor. Ironically, Sequoia Capital had withdrawn from Latin America in 2012 for lack of technical talent, yet backed Vêlez anyway—“there was no pitch. We invested 80% based on him,” recalled partner Doug Leone (Sequoia Capital, 2021). In 2019 SoftBank's US\$5 billion Latin America fund flooded the region with capital; in 2020 the COVID-19 pandemic accelerated digital adoption by years, just as Nubank was launching in Mexico; and the 2022 global rate shock later forced fintechs to prove they could be profitable, which Nubank did in 2023. Table 1 summarizes the timeline that leads to, and follows, the decision.

Table 1. Timeline of the case and its context (case decision point in bold)

Year	Nubank / case events	Brazil, Mexico and global context
2008–2012	Vêlez moves to Brazil (opening a bank account takes five months); as a Sequoia partner he decides to build a digital bank after Sequoia leaves Latin America in 2012.	Global financial crisis; smartphones reach the mass market; Brazil's commodity boom ends.
2013	May 6: Nubank founded in São Paulo by Vêlez, Cristina Junqueira (ex-Itaú) and Edward Wible; US\$2 million seed round led by Sequoia and Kaszek.	June: mass protests across Brazil; Law 12,865 creates payment institutions.
2014	Purple no-fee Mastercard launched (first transaction April 1); Series A of US\$14.3 million.	<i>Lava Jato</i> begins; Rousseff re-elected; recession starts.
2015–2016	Viral waiting list; 1 million customers by 2016; Series B (Tiger Global), C (Founders Fund) and D (DST Global).	GDP falls 3.5% and 3.3%; Selic at 14.25%; Rousseff impeached (2016).
2017	NuConta digital account (October) and Nubank Rewards launched; engineering office opened in Berlin to attract talent.	BCB limits revolving credit to 30 days; unemployment peaks near 13%.

2018	Presidential decree (Jan.) and BCB authorization (Nov.) for Nu Financeira; 5 million customers (Sept.); Tencent invests US\$180 million at a US\$4 billion valuation (Oct.).	Mexico enacts its Fintech Law (March); Resolution 4,656 licenses lending fintechs; Bolsonaro elected; AMLO takes office in Mexico (Dec.).
2019	Case decision point: ~6 million clients; personal loans launched; offices opened in Mexico City (GM Emilio González) and Argentina; July: Series F of US\$400 million led by TCV at a US\$10 billion valuation with 12 million customers; net loss of R\$312 million.	Selic falls to 4.5%; Instituto Locomotiva counts 45 million unbanked Brazilians; SoftBank's US\$5 billion LatAm fund; Banxico launches CoDi.
2020	March: no-fee credit card launched in Mexico; entry into Colombia; 20+ million customers; the HBS case is published (August).	COVID-19 pandemic accelerates digital banking; Pix launched in Brazil (November).
2021–2023	Nu México buys the SOFIPO Akala (Sept. 2021); Berkshire Hathaway invests; IPO on the NYSE on December 9, 2021 (~US\$41.5 billion); Cuenta Nu launched in Mexico with a 9% yield (May 2023); first profitable year (2023).	Open Finance starts in Brazil; 2022 rate shock crushes fintech valuations; Brazil caps revolving card debt at 2x (2023).
2024–2025	100 million customers (May 2024) and 114 million by year-end; CNBV approves Nu México's banking license (April 2025); 10+ million Mexican customers.	ENIF 2024: Mexicans with a credit card up almost 50% since 2021; former BCB governor Roberto Campos Neto joins Nubank.
2026	Nu México authorized to operate as a bank (July) with 16 million customers and a US\$4.2 billion investment plan to 2030; 2Q26 net income of US\$1.1 billion; 139 million customers (118 M Brazil, 16 M Mexico, 5 M Colombia).	Conditional U.S. bank-charter approval (Jan.); Pix processes more transactions than cards in Brazil.

Sources: Chu et al. (2020); Sequoia Capital (2021); Estadão (2018); Seu Dinheiro (2018); Nubank (2019); Forex.com (2021); Nu International (2023, 2025); Reuters (2025); Finextra (2026); Mexico Business News (2026).

4. The business situation and the challenges Nubank faced

At the decision point Nubank was the fastest-growing financial institution in Brazil and, in its own words, the largest digital bank in the world outside Asia. Its model rested on four pillars: (1) a no-fee, radically transparent product that incumbents could not copy without cannibalizing billions in fee income; (2) a cost structure a fraction of a branch bank's, built on proprietary cloud software, data-driven credit models and chat-based service by young “Xpeers” empowered to solve problems; (3) growth driven almost entirely by word of mouth, which kept acquisition costs near zero and Net Promoter Scores far above the industry; and (4) patient venture capital that financed years of losses—R\$312 million in 2019 and R\$230 million in 2020 (Forex.com, 2021). In 2017–2019 it had begun to evolve from a single product into a platform: NuConta (8 million users by mid-2019), Rewards, personal loans (offered to more than 500,000 customers within months) and an account for small businesses (Nubank, 2019).

Yet the situation was far from comfortable. First, the Brazilian disruption was unfinished: 6–12 million customers in a country of 210 million with 45 million unbanked meant the home market alone could absorb all of Nubank's capital and attention. Second, incumbents were finally reacting—Bradesco's *next*, Itaú's *iti*, Santander's *Superdigital*—while digital rivals such as Banco Inter, C6 Bank, Neon, PicPay and Mercado Pago multiplied, and the central bank's Pix and Open Finance agenda threatened to commoditize some of Nubank's advantages while opening new ones. Third, the economics were fragile: revenue depended on card interchange and interest in an economy recovering from recession, credit losses had to be managed with limited positive credit data, and every new product required a new license. Fourth, talent was scarce, which is why Nubank had opened an engineering office in Berlin. Against this backdrop, Vélez argued that

Nubank's true market was not Brazil but the 650 million people of Latin America, and that Mexico—large, underbanked, concentrated and geographically the gateway to the region—was the place to prove that the model traveled.

5. Definition of the central problem and the variables that affect it

Central problem. In 2019, with roughly six million customers, a US\$4 billion valuation, growing losses and incumbents beginning to respond at home, should Nubank commit scarce capital, engineering talent and management attention to replicate its digital-banking model in Mexico—a larger unbanked market with a different regulatory path, competitive set, credit infrastructure and consumer culture—or concentrate on deepening its still-incomplete disruption of Brazil? And if it goes, *how* should it enter: with which product, under which license, with what team and at what pace? It is a classic trade-off between depth and breadth in international expansion, complicated by the fact that Nubank's advantage was partly built on Brazil-specific conditions. Table 2 lists the variables that determine the answer and why each one matters.

Table 2. Relevant variables of the central problem

Variable	Why it matters for the decision
Size of the inclusion gap in each market	Brazil still had 45 million unbanked; Mexico had 53% of adults without an account and 69% without formal credit. The larger gap in Mexico is the main argument to go; the unfinished gap in Brazil is the main argument to stay.
Regulatory pathway and regulator attitude	In Brazil the BCB actively promoted competition and Nubank already held a financial-institution license; in Mexico it would have to climb from SOFOM to SOFIPO to bank (completed only in 2025–2026), limiting products, deposit funding and speed.
Competitive intensity, incumbent response and timing	Brazilian incumbents were launching digital banks; in Mexico the foreign-owned oligopoly and local fintechs (Klar, Stori, albo, Mercado Pago) were scaling in 2019–2020. Entering early could lock in leadership (16 million customers by 2026); entering with an incomplete product could burn capital and reputation.
Capital availability and runway	Expansion had to be financed with venture money while the Brazilian operation still lost hundreds of millions of reais; the US\$400 million Series F of July 2019 was raised precisely to fund new products and internationalization.
Unit economics: acquisition cost, cost to serve, revenue mix	Word-of-mouth growth and a low cost structure made the model viable in Brazil; whether Mexicans would refer friends at the same rate, and whether interchange and interest income would cover risk in a cash economy, was unknown.
Credit-risk data and infrastructure	Models trained on Brazilian bureaus (Serasa, Boa Vista) do not transfer automatically to Mexico's Buró de Crédito and a 55%-informal labor market; mispriced risk could destroy the entry.
Portability of the technology platform	A cloud-native, proprietary core lowers the marginal cost of a second market, but localization—Spanish, peso, tax, KYC, card processing—still consumes scarce engineering time.
Talent, organization and management focus	With about 2,000 employees and a Berlin office created because of talent scarcity, every engineer sent to Mexico was one less improving the Brazilian product; opportunity cost is a real variable.
Macroeconomic and political risk	Brazil's recovery was fragile and Mexico's new government was hostile to bank fees yet unpredictable; exchange-rate swings affect dollar-denominated funding and valuation.

Cultural fit and brand transferability	Nubank's brand meant transparency and a “cool” purple card in Brazil; in Mexico the same product could be seen as a risky foreign start-up in a cash-loving market —later addressed with the <i>moradita</i> card and secured cards for people with no credit history.
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6. Stakeholders: who is involved, their roles and their connections

The decision touched a dense web of individuals, companies and institutions in two countries. Table 3 identifies them; the paragraph that follows explains how they are connected.

Table 3. Stakeholder map of the case

Stakeholder	Role in the case	Connection to the problem
David Vélez (founder & CEO)	Colombian ex-Sequoia partner; framed Latin America, not Brazil, as the market.	Owner of the decision; his regional ambition versus the team's capacity to execute.
Cristina Junqueira and Edward Wible (co-founders)	Junqueira, ex-Itaú credit-card executive, led product and later Nubank Brazil; Wible, American engineer, built the technology.	Junqueira embodies the Brazilian focus; Wible's platform determines whether the model can be exported cheaply.
Employees (~2,000 in 2019: Xpeers, engineers, Berlin office)	Deliver the service culture and the software that are the real competitive advantage.	Scarce talent must be split between Brazil and a new country; the culture must be transplanted.
Venture investors: Sequoia, Kaszek, Tiger Global, Founders Fund, DST Global, Tencent, TCV, QED, Ribbit (later Berkshire Hathaway)	Financed years of losses; Tencent brought Chinese fintech know-how; TCV's US\$400 million round funded internationalization.	They expect regional scale to justify a US\$10 billion valuation, but also discipline in burning capital.
Customers in Brazil (6–12 million, mostly young and urban) and the 45 million unbanked	Source of revenue, referrals and brand; the unbanked are the mission.	Any dilution of service quality at home risks the word-of-mouth engine that finances expansion.
Mexican consumers (53% without an account; later 16 million Nu customers, about half with no prior credit)	Target market of the expansion.	Their cash habits, informality and distrust dictate product design (no-fee card, secured card, high-yield account).
Banco Central do Brasil and National Monetary Council	Licensed Nubank as payment institution and financial institution; pushed pro-competition reforms (Pix, Open Finance).	A supportive regulator at home versus an unknown one abroad; its former governor, Roberto Campos Neto, joined Nubank in 2025 as global head of public policy.
Mexican authorities: CNBV, Banco de México, SHCP, CONDUSEF	Gatekeepers of SOFOM/SOFIPO/ bank licenses and consumer protection under the 2018 Fintech Law.	Determined the speed and scope of Nu México's products (deposits only from 2023, bank status in 2026).
Incumbent banks: Itaú, Bradesco, Banco do Brasil, Caixa and Santander in Brazil; BBVA, Citibanamex, Santander, Banorte, HSBC and Scotiabank in Mexico	The oligopolies Nubank was created to disrupt; Brazilian ones launched digital banks (<i>next</i> , <i>iti</i>).	Their counter-attack raises the cost of neglecting Brazil, while Mexico's banks have deep pockets and political access.
Fintech rivals: Banco Inter, C6, Neon, PicPay, Mercado Pago (Brazil); Klar, Stori, albo, Ualá, RappiPay (Mexico)	Compete for the same underbanked customers and the same venture capital.	Speed of entry matters because these players were scaling in 2019–2020.

Partners: Mastercard, Amazon Web Services, credit bureaus (Serasa Experian, Boa Vista, Buró de Crédito, Círculo de Crédito)	Provide the card network, cloud infrastructure and risk data.	Their availability and pricing in Mexico condition unit economics and credit quality.
Governments, society and media (Temer's 2018 decree; AMLO's administration; social networks in both countries)	Set the political climate toward foreign fintechs and bank fees; amplify the brand; financial inclusion is a public-policy goal.	A presidential decree was needed in Brazil; anti-bank rhetoric in Mexico was both opportunity and risk; legitimacy depends on visibly serving the excluded.

How the pieces connect. The founders' regional vision could only be pursued because investors kept financing losses in exchange for growth, and investors did so because customers kept referring new customers at almost no cost—a virtuous circle that depends on employees sustaining service quality. Regulators sit at the center of the web: the BCB's decision to license Nubank and to open the market with Pix and Open Finance made the Brazilian circle possible, while the CNBV's slower licensing ladder dictated that Nu México would start with a single credit card in March 2020, add deposits only after buying Akala in 2021, launch Cuenta Nu in 2023 and become a bank in 2026. Incumbents and fintech rivals in both countries determine how much time Nubank has before the window closes, and partners such as Mastercard and AWS make the model exportable in the first place. Any solution proposed in Part 2—how, when and with what product to enter Mexico—will have to be negotiated with each of these actors.

7. What is at stake

Seen from 2026 the story has a known ending: Nu México is the largest digital bank in Mexico, with 16 million customers, a full banking license and a US\$4.2 billion investment plan through 2030, and Nu Holdings earns more than US\$1 billion per quarter serving 139 million people (Finextra, 2026; Mexico Business News, 2026; The Motley Fool, 2026). But in 2019 none of that was obvious. Nubank was a loss-making start-up whose advantage had been built on Brazilian regulation, Brazilian social habits and Brazilian data, and Mexico was a country where cash, informality, a foreign-owned banking oligopoly and a cautious regulator could easily have absorbed its capital without returning a single peso. This first part has reconstructed that moment—the place, the environment, the timeline, the problem and the people—so that Part 2 can evaluate the strategic routes Nubank could have taken and propose the one that best fits the differences, not only the similarities, between the two largest countries of Latin America.

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